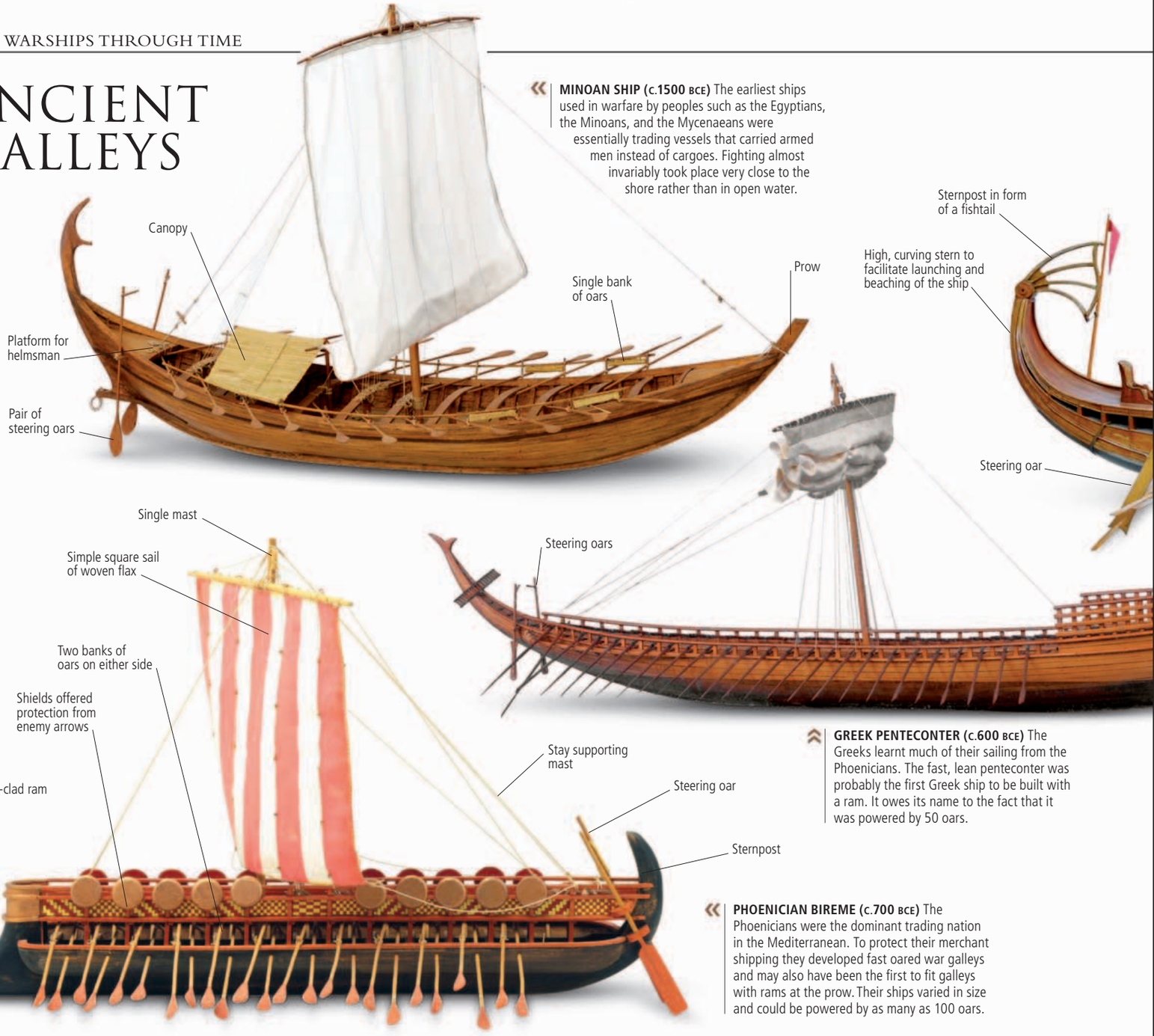
ANCIENT GALLEYS



MINOAN SHIP (c.1500 BCE) The earliest ships used in warfare by peoples such as the Egyptians, the Minoans, and the Mycenaeans were essentially trading vessels that carried armed men instead of cargoes. Fighting almost invariably took place very close to the shore rather than in open water.

GREEK PENTECONTER (c.600 BCE) The Greeks learnt much of their sailing from the Phoenicians. The fast, lean penteconter was probably the first Greek ship to be built with a ram. It owes its name to the fact that it was powered by 50 oars.

PHOENICIAN BIREME (c.700 BCE) The Phoenicians were the dominant trading nation in the Mediterranean. To protect their merchant shipping they developed fast oared war galleys and may also have been the first to fit galleys with rams at the prow. Their ships varied in size and could be powered by as many as 100 oars.

WARSHIPS THROUGH TIME

THE HISTORY OF WARSHIP DEVELOPMENT is an epic one, stretching from oared galleys and longships to modern aircraft carriers and nuclear submarines. As well as superb fighting machines, many warships have been masterpieces of design.

THE MEDITERRANEAN was the focus for the early development of warships. The first boats used in battle were civilian vessels turned to military use, such as those made from pitch-coated reeds that the Egyptians utilized in the 12th century BCE. They were used to carry soldiers and served as platforms for archers and spearmen. In the course of the 1st millennium BCE, maritime states around the Mediterranean developed fighting galleys, the first purpose-built warships.

GALLEY WARFARE

Galleys were propelled in battle by banks of oars. The galley's sail, typically on a single mast in the center of the ship, was generally not used in combat. Greek and Phoenician naval designers created the penteconter, then the bireme (two banks of oars) and trireme (three banks). Fast and maneuverable, these galleys were themselves weapons—a ram at the bow was used to smash the hulls of enemy boats. Over time more oars were added to drive much larger galleys called polyremes, which could be packed with soldiers and with catapults serving as shipborne artillery. Galleys remained the key warships of the Mediterranean throughout the period of the Roman Empire and its successor, the Byzantine Empire, whose dromons were frequently armed with the formidable incendiary weapon known as "Greek fire."